# The TidyMargin Pricing Playbook

A practical guide to pricing cleaning work for profit. It goes with the Premium workbook. It is general business education, not legal, tax or financial advice.

## 1. Start with time, not with the competition

Most cleaning businesses set prices by copying a competitor or a national average. Their costs, speed and local market are not yours. Time is the base of every good price, because labor is usually your largest cost.

How to measure your speed in one week:

1. On every job this week, write down the square feet, bedrooms, bathrooms, service type and the total labor hours (two cleaners for 3 hours = 6 labor hours).
2. For standard cleans, divide square feet by labor hours. That is your **sq ft per labor hour**.
3. Compare deep and move-out cleans with standard cleans of similar size. That ratio is your **service multiplier** (for example, a deep clean taking 1.8 times as long gives a 1.8 multiplier).
4. Enter the results in Settings. Repeat every few months; crews get faster with experience.

## 2. Know your real hourly cost

Pay per hour is not your cost per hour. Add:

- **Payroll burden** - employer payroll taxes, workers compensation and similar. Your accountant or payroll provider can tell you your number.
- **Non-billable time** - drive time, loading the car, training, gaps between jobs. Use the Crew Cost sheet: if a cleaner is billable 75% of paid hours, every billable hour really costs 1.33 paid hours.
- **Overhead** - insurance, bonding, phone, software, marketing, equipment. Divide the monthly total by your jobs per month and every job carries its fair share.

## 3. Price for margin, not markup

Decide what share of each dollar you want to keep after all costs: your **net margin**. Then price = cost / (1 - margin - card fee %).

| Your cost | Markup 30% | Real margin | Price for a true 30% margin |
|---|---|---|---|
| $100 | $130.00 | 23.1% | $142.86 |
| $150 | $195.00 | 23.1% | $214.29 |
| $200 | $260.00 | 23.1% | $285.71 |

The Price Calculator does this for you. It also includes card fees and rounds up.

## 4. Set a minimum job price

Small jobs still need a drive, setup, cleanup and a slot in your day that could have gone to a bigger job. A minimum price protects every booking. To find yours: take your shortest reasonable job (for example 2 labor hours), price it in the calculator and round up.

## 5. Frequency discounts that do not hurt you

Recurring clients are valuable: steady income, faster cleans after the first visit and no marketing cost. A discount for weekly or every-2-weeks service is common, but it must come out of savings, not out of your profit.

- Price the visit you actually deliver at your target margin (YOUR PRICE).
- Show the client the **Regular price** and the discount. The calculator works backwards so the discounted price still meets your margin.
- Charge first visits (often a deep clean) separately, at the deep-clean price.

## 6. Present prices with confidence

- Send a written estimate for every job. A clear, branded estimate looks professional and avoids "I thought that was included".
- Describe what is included. Attach the matching checklist from the workbook.
- Offer good / better / best when it makes sense, for example a standard clean, a standard clean plus inside the oven and fridge, or a deep clean.
- Put the condition rule in writing: "Final price may change if the home's condition differs from what was described."
- Never apologize for your price. Explain what it includes.

## 7. When and how to raise prices

Signs it is time: your schedule is full, your pay rate or supplies went up, or the Monthly Summary shows net margin below target for three months.

1. Re-run your current clients in the Quote Table with up-to-date Settings.
2. Decide the new price per client. Many owners raise recurring clients once a year.
3. Give 30 days' notice in writing.
4. Thank them and explain briefly. Example:

> *"Hi Jordan, thank you for trusting us with your home this year. To keep paying our team fairly and using quality supplies, our price for your every-2-weeks clean will be $175 starting March 1. Nothing else changes. If you have any questions, just reply to this message. We appreciate you!"*

## 8. Bidding commercial work

1. **Walk the space.** Measure or confirm square feet by area type (offices, restrooms, kitchens, lobbies). Restrooms and kitchens take longer than open offices.
2. **Agree the scope in writing**: which tasks, how often, what time of day, who supplies paper goods and liners.
3. **Estimate production time.** Use your own timing whenever you can. If you must start from an assumption, label it and check it after the first two weeks.
4. **Enter the bid** in the Commercial Bid sheet: sq ft, sq ft per hour, visits per week, pay, supplies per visit and the overhead you assign to the account.
5. **Quote a monthly price** (52 weeks / 12 months = 4.33 weeks per month), with the price per visit as a reference.
6. **Review after 30 days.** If the real hours are higher than the bid, talk to the client early about the scope or the price.

## 9. The weekly money routine (15 minutes)

1. Mark finished visits as Completed in the Schedule.
2. Log payments received and expenses paid in Transactions; mark anything unpaid as Pending.
3. Check the Dashboard: unpaid balances, clients to follow up and next week's bookings.
4. Once a month, compare the month with the previous one on the Monthly Summary and look at revenue per labor hour.

## 10. Common pricing mistakes

- Pricing from national averages instead of your own time and costs.
- Forgetting payroll taxes, drive time and card fees.
- Treating markup as margin.
- Giving recurring discounts that come out of profit.
- No minimum price.
- Not raising prices for years while costs go up.
- Confusing a busy month with a profitable month. Check the net margin and the cash flow.

Questions? Reply to your purchase email. We read every message.